# Walk in the Spirit

## Galatians 5:13-26

*Small Group Bible Study Series*

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Editor: The Gospel Vault

| ① TEXT | ② DEVOTIONAL | ③ COMMENTARY | ④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE |
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| Foundation | Personal prep | Teacher preparation | Group meeting |
| Everyone | All group members | Teacher / Leader | Small group |

## ① BIBLICAL TEXT

*NKJV · Galatians 5:13-26*

**13** *For you, brethren, have been called to liberty; only do not use liberty as an opportunity for the flesh, but through love serve one another.*

**14** *For all the law is fulfilled in one word, even in this: "You shall love your neighbor as yourself."*

**15** *But if you bite and devour one another, beware lest you be consumed by one another!*

**16** *I say then: Walk in the Spirit, and you shall not fulfill the lust of the flesh.*

**17** *For the flesh lusts against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh; and these are contrary to one another, so that you do not do the things that you wish.*

**18** *But if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law.*

**19** *Now the works of the flesh are evident, which are: adultery, fornication, uncleanness, lewdness,*

**20** *idolatry, sorcery, hatred, contentions, jealousies, outbursts of wrath, selfish ambitions, dissensions, heresies,*

**21** *envy, murders, drunkenness, revelries, and the like; of which I tell you beforehand, just as I also told you in time past, that those who practice such things will not inherit the kingdom of God.*

**22** *But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, kindness, goodness, faithfulness,*

**23** *gentleness, self-control. Against such there is no law.*

**24** *And those who are Christ's have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires.*

**25** *If we live in the Spirit, let us also walk in the Spirit.*

**26** *Let us not become conceited, provoking one another, envying one another.*

## ② DEVOTIONAL

*Personal preparation · All group members*

> ***"Freedom was never the end goal. Willing love was."***

God did not make us unable to sin, because he wanted willing obedience, not forced compliance. Christ has already made us free positionally; the daily call is to bring our experience up into that position —either to indulge the flesh (sin is a choice and may come with a consequence) or to serve one another in love (true fellowship), and the choice is genuinely ours to make.

The old nature does not vanish the moment we believe; it stays with us as a real, constant pull — the very tension Paul himself describes, doing the thing he hates. Walking in the Spirit is not automatic. The Spirit never forces His way; He waits to be trusted, step by step, in the small things before the large ones.

The works of the flesh are obvious enough that Paul barely needs to explain them, but the fruit of the Spirit — love, joy, peace, and the rest — doesn't come from trying harder. It comes from the root, the way oranges come from an orange tree, not from being tied on.

**Reflect**

1. In what area of your life have you been using "liberty as an opportunity for the flesh" rather than serving through love?
2. Where are the flesh and the Spirit most obviously in conflict in you right now — and are you trying to win that fight by self-effort or by yielding to the Spirit?
3. If someone had to look for evidence of the Spirit's fruit in your life this week, what would they actually find?

*Since we live in the Spirit, let us also walk in the Spirit.*

# ③ COMMENTARY

*Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings*

**Proposition:** *Christian liberty is not the freedom to indulge the flesh but the freedom, secured by Christ's cross, to walk continually in step with the Holy Spirit — who alone produces, as fruit rather than forced works, the loving service, self-control, and harmony that the law could only demand and never supply.*

### Introduction

Paul has made a shift here. He's been telling the Judaizers: quit what you're doing, quit trying to subvert the people's salvation — they came to know Jesus Christ by grace through faith, plus not one thing, and don't you try to get them back under the law some way. Now, at this point, he makes a shift — not to the Judaizers; from here to the conclusion of the epistle, the Judaizers aren't mentioned again until 6:12-13 and 16. It's all about the believers now. The shift is signaled by the word — you guessed it — "brethren." Now, brethren, verse 13: "For you, brethren…" — that's where he's going. The emphasis now is on them, on us — not on those people who would try to subvert us, not on those people out there who say things against what we teach. It's on us. He's saying: now you know the truth, I've told you the truth in these first four and a half chapters; now I want you to know something about what you need to do. And what you need to do is walk in the Spirit. And when I say "you," I'm saying three fingers point back here and one out there. All of us need to walk in the Spirit.

## I. The Potential of Liberty – 5:13-15

He starts off in verse 13 to say, "For you, brethren, have been called to liberty." Isn't that great? You've been called to liberty — you haven't been called to a bunch of rules, you haven't been called to follow the Mosaic law, however great it once was; it isn't incumbent on us now. He's already told them in 5:1, "Christ has made you free" — that's our positional freedom. When we come to know the Lord, believe on him, receive eternal life, we are free. Some people get the idea that when we were in the bondage of sin, in the bondage of some works religion maybe, and along comes Christ and says, "You're free — now you have to follow me" — as if we exchanged one bondage for another: "I'm a slave of sin, now I'm a slave of Christ." Not true. You are free — totally free. We are free positionally. But now he exhorts them to bring their experience up to their position. Our position is freedom; now bring your experience into that freedom — be free. Even though we now have freedom, and it's real — we are a new creation, with the freedom to serve or not to serve. That's our freedom: freedom either to serve or not serve. You are free.

Why did God not make Adam and Eve so that they couldn't sin? Wouldn't that be simpler? "God, what are you doing?" Why didn't he say, "Okay, here you are, now you can't sin, I won't let you sin"? Well, what would that be doing? You know why God didn't do that? Because he wanted willing obedience. He wanted us to willingly serve him. God does not force us to serve

him, but he does reward willing obedience — to the extent that we've willingly served him here, to that extent we will be able to serve him there, in his kingdom of righteousness. We were made free for the purpose of living for and serving Christ willingly.

### A. We Can Exploit Our Liberty through License – 5:13a

*"only do not use liberty as an opportunity for the flesh,"*

Now, he's saying, you have liberty — now don't exploit that liberty with license. It says, "only do not use liberty as an opportunity for the flesh." One of the greatest criticisms of the free grace gospel is: "Well, you people teach that they can sin all they want to." We don't teach that, and the apostle Paul never taught that. But it must be possible for a believer to do this, or Paul would not have to tell them not to — so the person who is a believer can use his liberty as an opportunity for the flesh.

Having said this, let me add: there are consequences to sin, and they will come. Hebrews 12 says, "whom the Lord loves he chastens, and scourges every son whom he receives" — meaning, when he needs it, because we're in the family now. The Word of God to us is: be sinless, and serve the Lord. Now the rewards can be lost or gained. And also, there is a Savior who will be scorned if we don't. Hebrews 10:29 says that we can "tread underfoot the blood of Christ" — if we do not serve him, all we're saying is his blood is nothing, I'll step on it, I don't care, step on it, that's it. And that can happen when we don't serve the Lord willingly. So we can exploit our liberty through license, or we can explore our liberty through love.

### B. We Can Explore Our Liberty through Love – 5:13b-14

*"but through love serve one another."*

1. The Request to Loving Service – 5:13b. Verse 13b is a request for loving service: "But through love serve one another." We've been set free so that we might serve one another — that we might serve Jesus himself — but he won't force us to do that. He set the example: remember, the night before he was betrayed, he gave the Lord's Table before them, but before that, they came into the room. In those days they wore sandals — they didn't wear socks, they're like some of my students; we used to have a rule, you have to wear socks — they didn't like that. These people didn't wear any socks, they wore sandals, and as they walked through the dusty streets their feet got dirty. Usually some servant was at the door to wash people's feet when they came in. They had secured a room — probably John Mark's mother's — for this, and they all came in and said, "Well, we're going to have a supper here, let's go, the Passover meal." Jesus was waiting, waiting — nobody decided to do it, because they thought, well, the lowly person, the servant, ought to do that. So Jesus finally got up, took off his outer garment, put a towel around his waist, and said, "I'm going to wash your feet." He got a basin, filled it with water, washed their feet. So he gave the example — he washed their feet. The Lord of the universe, the most important person in the whole universe, the one who created all things, is washing their feet, performing this menial task.

Well, somebody might say, maybe he didn't know who he was. No — that can't be true, because here's what he says in John 13:3: "Jesus, knowing that the Father had given all things

into his hands, and that he had come from God and was going to God" — he washed their feet. He knew it all; he knew who he was and what he was doing. And he said, "If I then, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet, you also ought to wash one another's feet."

Now, I don't understand this as another ordinance for the church — we have ordinances, baptism and the Lord's Table, two ordinances we observe, and some people have a third, foot-washing. Well, that's all right, I have no problem with that. But washing feet is simply, I think, a picture of doing things for each other — the most lowly task is not beneath us. That's real love. That's what he's saying.

2. The Result of Loving Service – 5:14. The result of loving service is this — verse 14: "For all the law is fulfilled in one word, even in this, that you love your neighbor as yourself." Paul may be saying, in effect, "You want to keep the law? Here's the way you do it — love your neighbor as yourself." That was in Leviticus 19:18. How so? Well, that love fulfills the law with respect to other people. Somebody asked Jesus, "What's the most important law?" And he said, two of them: "Love the Lord your God" — that's the first five commandments — and "love your neighbor as yourself" — that's the second five. You look at them, you'll see that. So loving your neighbor as yourself was the second one that Jesus mentioned — loving the Lord your God, that was no problem, they loved the Lord, so he concentrates on the other: love your neighbor as yourself. So, you want to keep the law? Okay, keep that part. What it amounts to is this: Jesus is first, others are second, and I'm last. That's love. That's the way we ought to be living the Christian life.

### C. We Can Enjoy Our Liberty through Living in Harmony with One Another – 5:15

> *"But if you bite and devour one another, beware lest you be consumed by one another!"*

So we can exploit our liberty with license, we can explore our liberty in love, and we can enjoy our liberty through living in harmony with other people. "If you bite and devour one another, beware lest you be consumed by one another." These words are not describing the Judaizers — remember, he's not talking to them — and they're not describing unbelievers either. He's talking about believers. Believers can bite and devour one another. If you don't think that's possible, you should have been with me in some of the business meetings we've had in churches. People can do that — all of you can see them get all excited and really do some strange things. I've been the butt of some of that in regular church meetings. It can ruin lives — people walk out of business meetings and say, "I'll never come back, I'll never go to another church again." I've heard people do that — my brother did that, and he kept it until his dying day. It can ruin churches — not only one person, but half of a church can walk out. I pastored a church in South Miami; the other half that stayed there kept the building — it was just a big split in the church, and I had some problems with that group that stayed there. So, what I'm saying is, it can ruin us, and believers can do that.

How do we avoid this? I'm glad you asked — the answer is coming up.

## II. The Performance of Liberty – 5:16-18

### A. The Command to Walk in the Spirit – 5:16

> *"I say then: Walk in the Spirit, and you shall not fulfill the lust of the flesh."*

Now, secondly, the performance of liberty, verses 16 to 18. The command is to walk in the Spirit: "I say then, walk in the Spirit, and you will not fulfill the lust of the flesh." How do you keep from fulfilling the lust of the flesh? You walk in the Spirit. How do you walk in the Spirit? You hear the word the Spirit gave, and then rely upon the Spirit to allow you to do that, to empower you to do that.

In 1 Corinthians 2 and 3, Paul talks about three kinds of people. There are natural people — people who don't know Jesus Christ as Savior, they're not born again. They are natural, and he says the natural man cannot receive the things of God, for they are a mystery to him. When he does believe, though, he's born again, he receives the Holy Spirit, the enablement to understand these things. Then there are two kinds of believers — one kind is carnal Christians. Carnal Christians are worldly Christians, or maybe even newborn Christians — a person who is just born again is a carnal Christian; he hasn't grown, because you can be a carnal Christian either because you're young in the faith, or because you're just worldly, following the things of the world and not walking in the Spirit. Those who are walking by the Spirit, then, are the spiritual ones. So here Paul is telling us how to be spiritual Christians.

The word "walk" here [περιπατεῖτε] — we had "walk" before, and it meant "walk around." It means, in all your daily walk, do this. Walking in the Spirit is not just when I go to church, or when I'm doing some ministry for the Lord — it means, in your daily life, wherever you go, whatever you do, walk in the Spirit. Walk by means of the Spirit — that is, in the power which the Holy Spirit gives, allowing him to work through us. He will never — there's a double negative there [οὐ μή] — lead us into carrying out the desires of the flesh. But he does not do his work automatically; he waits for the believer to yield control to him. So that's the command: walk in the Spirit.

### B. The Conflict between the Flesh and the Spirit – 5:17

> *"For the flesh lusts against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh; and these are contrary to one another, so that you do not do the things that you wish."*

Now there's a conflict. Once you have that, there's a conflict: the flesh lusts, or fights, wars against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh, and these are contrary to one another, so that you do not do the things that you wish. There's a conflict in there. You still have that old nature, you still have those fleshly desires — you're not different in that respect, but you have the ability to overcome it. The Holy Spirit enters at salvation; he does not eliminate the flesh. You still have that old nature until the Lord either comes for you or calls for you. It will stay there. So the Spirit and the old nature are in constant conflict with one another.

Romans 7:15-25 says this — this is Paul talking about his own life after he was a believer: "For what I will to do, that I do not practice; but what I hate, that I do." Do you ever get that feeling?

Do you ever have that experience? No, no, no — I see your halos, you didn't do it! But it happens. Walking in the Spirit is a hard job. Sometimes we say, "I'm doing the wrong thing, I know I'm doing the wrong thing, I still do it." Why? Because I'm not allowing the Holy Spirit to lead. Victory in the Christian life comes by dependence upon the Holy Spirit, listening to what he says.

### C. The Call to be Led by the Spirit – 5:18

> *"But if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law."*

Now the call, verse 18, is the call to be led by the Spirit: "But if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law." Why bring that out? Because — no, you're not under the law, by following the Spirit. Being led by the Spirit doesn't refer to what dress to buy, what car to drive, what job to choose — it's the same as walking by the Spirit in verse 16, the desires of the Spirit in verse 17, and the walk of faith in verse 20.

"Not under the law" contrasts here with being led by the Spirit, in this way: the law went behind a person and drove him to keep the rules — and he did it grudgingly. There's the law back there, cracking the whip — gotta do this, gotta do this — and you walk along because you have to. But the Holy Spirit does it the other way. The Holy Spirit leads — he's out in front. He says, now do this, walk this way. So I either walk that way or I walk the other way — but if I'm walking with him, I'm just following along. He's leading the path, and I'm just following where he goes. Big difference. That's the difference between the law and the Spirit — walking after the Spirit, and I learn what the Spirit wants by the Word, by prayer, by his bringing it to my mind and wooing me to do the right thing. So I do it willingly.

## III. The Pictures of Liberty – 5:19-23

### A. The Portrait of the Sinful Man – 5:19-21

> *"Now the works of the flesh are evident, which are:"*

Now we have some pictures, or portraits, of liberty. First he gives us the portrait of the sinful man. "Now the works of the flesh are evident" — they're obvious. Here they are — which are these?

1. The Divisions of the Works of the Flesh. a. Sexual Sins: In there you'd expect to see adultery — the unlawful intercourse of one who is married, and one not married to the other person; in other words, a married person is involved, and they're not married to each other — that's adultery. I'm not going to go into detail, just give you a little snippet of what each of these means. Fornication — all kinds of sexual sins, including incest, all of that terrible stuff. Then uncleanness — moral uncleanness in either thought, word, or deed. Lewdness — open, shameless, brazen display of evil; it just reminds me of Mardi Gras, they're doing all that kind of stuff down there, that's brazen, that's it. Now, those are sexual sins.

b. Spiritual Sins: Idolatry — the worship of pagan gods, bowing down to idols, probably including the male and female prostitution that was often a part of the heathen religions. We'll talk about

idolatry a little later too, but idolatry is not just that — idolatry is anything that comes between you and the Lord, that's worshiping an idol. Your idol can be your car — I don't think mine will ever be that, but it can happen — or your truck, if that's all you have. So that's idolatry. Then sorcery — it's the word pharmakeia [φαρμακείᾳ], and people make a lot of things about, "Oh, pharmakeia, drugs" — what he's talking about is the use of drugs to create trances in worship. That's spiritual sins.

c. Social Sins: Then there are social sins — notice how many there are, a long list of them. So you say, "Oh, I don't commit that, I don't do that lewd stuff, no, I don't do that." Well, how about these? Hatred — I felt that one right here — the feeling of enmity between groups or individuals; that happens, it can be a group, it can be individuals, staring at each other, it can happen within the church, wherever you go, in your work, whatever. Contentions — discord, the natural result of hatred: if you have hatred for people, there will be contentions, or discord, among you. Jealousies — the sinful and self-centered type (all jealousy — I almost said something wrong, I started to say all jealousy is sinful — it's not; the Holy Spirit is jealous for us, we serve a jealous God, that's different — but our jealousy is the self-centered type, and we don't deserve the thing that we're jealous about). Outbursts of wrath — fits of rage, can't hold the temper, right along with the adultery and stuff. Selfish ambitions — nothing wrong with ambition, but working to get ahead at other people's expense, stepping all over people — and someone has said, you be careful how you step on people on the way up, you'll probably meet them all the way down. Dissensions — quarreling over issues or personalities, causing hurtful divisions, dissension among the group. Heresies — the word is just "divisions," but you can be divided about many things. Envy — wrongful desires to possess what belongs to someone else; sounds like covetousness, doesn't it? That's what it is. Murders — what's that? Killing people, that's what that is. And you can do that not only by a gun or a knife — you can do it by ruining someone's reputation, by the mouth you can be killing people. If you have murder in your heart, you've already killed a guy — by the way, if you have adultery in your heart, you've already done the deed. And then it ends with "and the like" — that's not all of them, it's not an exhaustive list, there are just many other things in there, in case I left something out, that's in there.

These are the types of sins that caused three of Jacob's sons to forfeit their inheritance, birthright, and blessing — you read about that in Genesis 49; three of Jacob's sons are not a part of the kingdom.

2. Danger of the Works of the Flesh. "Of which I tell you beforehand, just as I also told you in time past, that those who practice such things will not inherit the kingdom of God." Now, here's a real battleground, if you don't understand it in context — but there's no problem: inheriting the kingdom of God refers to ruling with Christ in the kingdom (Matthew 19:29; Revelation 2:26). It's not talking about entering the kingdom — it's talking about ruling with Christ in the kingdom. How do I know that? Well, they're brothers — remember, we talked about this, he called them brothers, they are brothers, they are believers, and they cannot fail to enter the kingdom, it's promised, they have eternal life. So it's not entering — it's being a part of the kingdom, ruling with Christ in his kingdom. So when believers live like unbelievers, they will not rule with Christ in his righteous kingdom.

## B. The Portrait of the Spiritual Man – 5:22-23

> *"But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control."*

1. The Upward Qualities of the Spiritual Man. So then we have the portrait of the spiritual man, verses 22 and 23. The upward qualities of the spiritual man: love. Love is the first one — the foundation one. Self-sacrificing love, agapē — self-sacrificing, not doing something for gain, but doing something in spite of the fact that I'm going to lose. That's love. Joy is a deep and abiding inner rejoicing — not a frivolous kind of thing, but an inner rejoicing in the things of the Lord. And then there's peace — an inner repose and quietness, even in the face of adverse circumstances; not easy to do, and we can't do it in ourselves, but we can do it in the gift of the Spirit.

These are the fruit of the Spirit — the Spirit indwells us, and the fruit that is evident from that, as we walk in the Spirit, as we depend upon the Spirit, those things will come: love, joy, peace — they're fruit. The others, remember, were works — the works of the flesh, and they're really a work too, hard work. But now he says the fruit of the Spirit. Well, suppose you had an orange tree, and you planted it out here, and everybody said, "What kind of tree is that?" "It's an orange tree." "I don't believe that, looks like a pear tree to me." "No, it's an orange tree." How do you prove that's an orange tree? Later on, oranges will come on it, they'll appear on it — you can go and tie some on there if you want, but the real fruit, the real orange, is going to be one that comes out from the root and becomes oranges. That's what it is with the fruit of the Spirit — the Holy Spirit is in it. How do you know the Holy Spirit is in me? How do you know I'm not a faker up here? Well, the fruit of the Spirit will tell — the only proof I have would be the fruit of the Spirit: the love, the joy, the peace that comes. No, it's not perfect — I'm working on it, he's working on me — but that's what I'm saying, these are fruit, and those are the upward qualities of the spiritual man.

2. The Outward Qualities of the Spiritual Man. Patience — oh, my — the quality of forbearance under provocation. Patience — if I have to hang on to something, that's not patience. Kindness — benevolent action such as God demonstrated toward man: while we were yet sinners, Christ died for the ungodly. Christ did not come down here and say, "Oh, Ray is such a nice guy, I think I'll die for him" — he's a sinner, ungodly, and Christ died for him. That's an act of kindness — that's God's kindness. Goodness — the uprightness of soul, reaching out to others, to do good even when it's not deserved. How many people do you know right now that you would sign everything you have over to? "It's yours, I'll sign her on my checking account, don't blame me, this is it" — that's a good person, that's a man who has goodness, I can trust him wherever — that's quite a thing.

3. The Inward Qualities of the Spiritual Man. Faithfulness — this is a quality that renders a person trustworthy and reliable, very much related to that goodness — a trustworthy person, one I can rely upon no matter what's going to happen, that's faithfulness. Gentleness — the person who is in submission to God's Word, who is considerate of others, even when discipline is needed. Sometimes when discipline comes, if you aren't careful, you can do it with a vengeance — that's not what it is. Somewhere along the line, someone has said that when you

discipline your child, the very next thing you ought to do is hold him in your arms and assure him of your love — that's gentleness. And then there's self-control — self-control denotes self-mastery, probably a conclusion or compilation of all these things, and no doubt primarily relates to the curbing of the fleshly impulses that were just described. That's the spiritual man.

## IV. The Participation in Our Liberty – 5:24-25

### A. The Provision for Liberty – 5:24

*"And those who are Christ's have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires."*

Now we talked about the potential, the performance, the pictures — now the participation in our liberty, verses 24 and 25: the provision for liberty, verse 24. "Those who are Christ's have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires." Now, this is not a reference to self-crucifixion, self-mutilation — not that — but rather it refers to the fact that by means of baptism, Spirit baptism, Christians have identified themselves with Christ in his death and resurrection. Remember, when I baptize somebody, water baptism is a picture of Spirit baptism, and we usually say, "I am buried with him in baptism, and resurrected to walk in newness of life." So we are emulating in our baptism what happened in our Spirit baptism, and what Christ has done for us — we are living in a self-crucifying way.

Now the provision is made; now the believer must continually lay hold of this truth, or a believer will be tempted to try to secure victory by self-effort. What he's saying here is that we cannot do this by ourselves — we must identify with the death and crucifixion of Christ, must identify with that and make that ours. What he did on the cross, he did for me, and he did as me — and so now I am going to take that and serve the Lord, overcome evil by that, or if I don't do that, then I'm doing it by myself. I was talking to a fellow the other day, and I said, "Jesus died in your place, he took your place on the cross, he paid for your sins." He said, "No, I'll pay my own way." I said, "You won't pay your way to heaven — not that way, no, can't do it."

### B. The Power for Liberty – 5:25

*"If we live in the Spirit, let us also walk in the Spirit."*

Now the power for liberty — how do we do this? "If we live in the Spirit" — verse 25 — "let us also walk in the Spirit." Now, that word "if" — people have mutilated that: "oh, if we walk, if you live in the Spirit, if you really are a believer" — he's not saying that. That word "if" can be translated, and very often is, "since" — since we live in the Spirit; that's necessary here, I believe. The clause is assumed to be true — assuming that we live in the Spirit, and we do, then let us walk by the Spirit.

Now this "walk" [στοιχῶμεν] is a different word than just walking around in your daily life. This word is walking in line, or in rank — it's a military term: walk, get in line, get in track. Who's the leader here, who's the sergeant, who's drilling us? Not the pastor, not Paul — it's the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit is our sergeant; he's right there telling us, go this way, follow me, get in line. That's what he's saying: walk in the Spirit, get in line, and you will not fulfill the lust of the flesh.

## C. The Particulars of Liberty – 5:26

*“Let us not become conceited, provoking one another, envying one another.”*

So the particulars of our liberty are in verse 26 — three things. "Let us not become conceited." The undergirding motive of conceit is pride — if I’m conceited, I’m proud of myself. Well, pride was the sin of the devil — in Ezekiel 28, and especially in Isaiah 14, he said, "I will be like the Most High." There are seven "I wills," I believe, in Isaiah 14, and one of them was, "I will be like the Most High" — wow, that’s conceit, that’s pride, and the New Testament refers often to that pride of the devil.

Then he says, "provoking one another" — my mother used to use that word, "you provoke me" — well, that’s bad, provoking people. There’s only one place in Scripture that says you can provoke somebody — you know what it is? Hebrews 10:25 says, "provoking one another to good works." Now, are we provoking people to good works, or are we provoking people to bad works? That’s what he’s saying — don’t provoke one another.

And don’t envy one another — don’t be jealous of another person’s possession or his position. A person who has something that I like — what I need to do is congratulate him: "Oh, that’s great, oh, you got that position, you got the raise, that’s wonderful, I’m glad to hear that" — and be serious about that, people can tell a fraud a mile away. Be serious: "I’m glad you got the position," even though I was in line for it — so don’t envy. The Lord wants you to have that position — you’ll get it, or another one better than that.

## Conclusion

These probably are the three groups that he’s identifying in Galatia, and I can see that these were caused by that Judaizing error — the Judaizers say, "you can do it yourself, don’t depend on anybody else, keep the law, if you do that God’s going to love you." No, that’s not what he’s saying. The only way that we can walk the Christian life is to walk by the Spirit. Don’t try to do it without him. You have the Holy Spirit — the moment you believe, you have the Holy Spirit, all of the Holy Spirit you’ll ever get — and walk in that Spirit, allow him to work through your life. Everything that we do, everything that we do — not just, well, I get the big things, no, every little thing. You learn to trust him in the little things — they’ll get bigger and bigger. Pretty soon you’re trusting him in a lot of things. That’s the spiritual man.

*Lord, thank You.*

# ④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

*For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text*

### Greek Word Study

| Verse | Greek Word / English | Strong's # / Translit. / Form | Definition & Significance |
|---|---|---|---|
| v.13 | **ἐλευθερίᾳ**<br>*liberty* | G1657<br>*eleutheria*<br>N-DSF | STR: freedom, chiefly moral or ceremonial. Significance: believers are called "to" liberty (dative of destination) — liberty is the goal of God's call, not a side benefit of it. |
| v.13 | **ἀφορμὴν**<br>*opportunity, occasion* | G874<br>*aphormēn*<br>N-ASF | STR: a starting-point; figuratively, an opportunity. THAY: a base of operations, an incentive or resource for an undertaking. Significance: originally a military staging-ground — Paul warns against turning freedom into a forward base for the flesh's campaign. |
| v.13 | **δουλεύετε**<br>*serve (as a slave)* | G1398<br>*douleuete*<br>V-PAM-2P | STR: to be a slave to, literal or figurative, involuntary or voluntary. Significance: a deliberate paradox — a freed people is commanded into a voluntary "slavery" to one another, but through love rather than law. |
| v.14 | **πεπλήρωται**<br>*is fulfilled* | G4137<br>*peplerotai*<br>V-RPI-3S (Perf. Pass. Ind. 3rd Sg.) | STR/THAY: to make full, complete; to satisfy a requirement fully. Significance: perfect tense — a settled, completed state: the entire law stands permanently satisfied in the single command to love one's neighbor. |
| v.16 | **περιπατεῖτε**<br>*walk* | G4043<br>*peripateite*<br>V-PAM-2P | STR: to tread all around; figuratively, to conduct one's life. Significance: an everyday-life verb — deliberately contrasted in v.25 with στοιχέω (below); walking in the Spirit governs ordinary days, not only formal ministry. |
| v.19 | **ἔργα τῆς σαρκός**<br>*works of the flesh* | G2041 / G4561<br>*erga tēs sarkos*<br>N-NPN / N-GSF | STR (ergon): a deed, that which is wrought or labored at. Significance: plural and effortful — self-produced acts, set in deliberate contrast with the singular "fruit" of v.22, which grows rather than being manufactured. |
| v.22 | **καρπός**<br>*fruit* | G2590<br>*karpos*<br>N-NSM | STR: fruit, as plucked, literally or figuratively. THAY: an effect or result that comes from something. Significance: singular — one fruit with many facets, grown from the root of the |

| Verse | Greek Word / English | Strong's # / Translit. / Form | Definition & Significance |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | indwelling Spirit rather than assembled piece by piece. |
| v.22 | **ἀγάπη**<br>*love* | G26<br>*agape*<br>N-NSF | Significance: named first among the fruit — the root quality Paul already identified in 5:6 as the mode in which faith itself operates; here it heads the list from which the rest of the fruit follow. |
| v.24 | **ἐσταύρωσαν**<br>*have crucified* | G4717<br>*estaurosan*<br>V-AAI-3P (Aor. Act. Ind. 3rd Pl.) | STR: to impale on the cross; figuratively, to subdue and extinguish passion. Significance: aorist — a completed identification with Christ's death, not an ongoing self-inflicted mortification, which the believer must continually lay hold of by faith. |
| v.25 | **στοιχῶμεν**<br>*let us walk (in rank)* | G4748<br>*stoichomen*<br>V-PAS-1P (Pres. Act. Subj. 1st Pl.) | STR: to march in military rank, keep step; figuratively, to conform to a standard. Significance: a different verb than περιπατέω in v.16 — corporate, ordered marching behind a leader, the Holy Spirit as drill sergeant, not solitary wandering. |
| v.26 | **κενόδοξοι**<br>*conceited* | G2755<br>*kenodoxoi*<br>A-NPM (used only here in the NT) | STR: vainly glorifying, self-conceited. Significance: a hapax legomenon — compounded from "empty" (kenos) and "glory" (doxa); the empty-glory root beneath the three closing vices (conceit, provocation, envy) that were splitting the Galatian congregation into factions. |

*Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc.* | *Number: Sg. · Pl.* | *Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut.* | *Verb Mood: Ind. · Impv. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc.* | *Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf.* | *Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass.* | *Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.*

## Study Questions

### Part 1 — From the Commentary

| Question | Answer |
|---|---|
| What's the difference between our positional and experiential freedom (5:1, 13)? | Positionally we are already completely free in Christ; experientially, we must choose day by day to bring our actual life up into that position — freedom is real but not automatically lived out. |
| Why did God give liberty rather than making us permanently unable to sin? | Because he wants willing obedience, not forced compliance — a love relationship, not a cage. |
| How does foot-washing (John 13) illustrate | The Lord of the universe performed the lowest |

| Question | Answer |
|---|---|
| "through love serve one another" (5:13)? | servant's task for his disciples, knowing exactly who he was — showing that no act of loving service is beneath a believer. |
| What is the real difference between the "works" of the flesh (5:19) and the "fruit" of the Spirit (5:22)? | Works are self-produced and effortful; fruit grows naturally from a root — the indwelling Spirit — as the believer walks in dependence on him. |
| Why does Paul use a different Greek word for "walk" in verse 25 than in verse 16? | Verse 16 uses a word for ordinary daily conduct; verse 25 uses a military term for marching in rank — walking in step together, under the Spirit's lead, not wandering alone. |

## Part 2 — Study Questions

**1. Paul says believers are free either to serve the flesh or to serve one another in love (5:13). Where do you find that choice hardest to make?**

> ***Leader note:*** *See Commentary I.A-B; keep the focus on the reality that this really is a live choice, not an automatic outcome of salvation.*

**2. What would it look like to "wash someone's feet" today — literally or figuratively — in your own relationships?**

> ***Leader note:*** *See Commentary I.B.1 and John 13:3-15.*

**3. Which of the works of the flesh in 5:19-21 do you find most tempting to excuse as "not that bad"? Why?**

> ***Leader note:*** *See Commentary III.A. Keep the group's focus on self-examination, not on judging others.*

**4. Which fruit of the Spirit in 5:22-23 do you most need to grow in right now, and what's one practical step toward depending on the Spirit for it?**

> ***Leader note:*** *See Commentary III.B and the orange-tree illustration — fruit grows from the root, it isn't tied on.*

**5. Paul closes with conceit, provoking, and envy (5:26) — three sins that can divide a church. Which have you seen do the most damage, and how do we guard against it?**

> ***Leader note:*** *See Commentary IV.C and the "three groups" observation. Steer discussion toward self-examination, not naming specific people or situations.*

## Part 3 — Passage Summary

| Verse(s) | Theme | Key Truth |
|---|---|---|
| 5:13-15 | The Potential of Liberty | Freedom can be exploited through license or explored through loving service; harmony, not biting and devouring, is the goal. |

| Verse(s) | Theme | Key Truth |
|---|---|---|
| 5:16-18 | The Performance of Liberty | Walking in the Spirit, not self-effort, is how the believer overcomes the flesh and is led rather than driven. |
| 5:19-23 | The Pictures of Liberty | The works of the flesh are obvious and self-produced; the fruit of the Spirit grows naturally from the Spirit's root. |
| 5:24-26 | The Participation in Liberty | Believers are identified with Christ's death, empowered to march in step with the Spirit, and warned against conceit, provocation, and envy. |

## ⑤ APPLICATION

*Closes the study · Personal & corporate*

### 1. Serve Through Love, Not License

***Scripture: Galatians 5:13***

*Drawn from Commentary I.A–B.*

Christian liberty gives you a real choice every day: use it as an opportunity for the flesh, or explore it through loving service. Jesus modeled the second by washing feet — the lowest task, done by the highest Person, so no task could ever again be "beneath" a believer.

**Reflection:** *Where have you been leaning toward license this week instead of loving service?*

**Practical Step:** Find one lowly, unglamorous task to do for someone this week — literally or figuratively "washing their feet" — without being asked and without mentioning it.

### 2. Walk in Step, Not Alone

***Scripture: Galatians 5:16, 25***

*Drawn from Commentary II.A and IV.B.*

Paul uses two different words for "walk": one for ordinary daily conduct, one for marching in rank behind a leader. Both describe the same Christian life — the Spirit is present in the routine of your day, and he is also the one setting the pace and direction.

**Reflection:** *In your daily routine, are you asking the Spirit to lead, or are you leading and hoping he keeps up?*

**Practical Step:** Pick one recurring decision point this week — a reaction, a habit, a conversation — and consciously pause to yield to the Spirit before acting, rather than after.

### 3. Let the Root Produce the Fruit

***Scripture: Galatians 5:22-23***

*Drawn from Commentary III.B.*

You cannot manufacture love, joy, or peace by trying harder any more than you can tie oranges onto a pear tree. Fruit is evidence of what is growing from the root, not a performance you produce for others to see.

**Reflection:** *Which fruit of the Spirit do you most lack right now — and have you been trying to produce it, or asking the Spirit to grow it?*

**Practical Step:** Name the one fruit you most need, and instead of resolving to try harder, spend specific time this week depending on and asking the Spirit for it.

### 4. Guard Against the Quiet Sins

***Scripture: Galatians 5:26***

*Drawn from Commentary IV.C and FGR (Howard Hendricks, As Iron Sharpens Iron).*

Conceit, provoking, and envy rarely announce themselves as church-splitting sins — they look like ordinary pride, ordinary irritation, ordinary comparison. Left alone, Paul says, they are exactly what factions form around. Character formed in honest relationship, as Hendricks describes it, is what keeps these quiet sins from taking root.

**Reflection:** *Is there a relationship in your church or family where envy or provoking has quietly crept in?*

**Practical Step:** Name that relationship, and take one deliberate step this week toward genuine encouragement or congratulation instead of comparison.

*End of Study · Galatians 5:13-26*